

TAKING EVERYONE ALONG

The global tech giant believes in inclusiveness and investing in employees' growth

By **Smita Tripathi**

▶ WHEN 32-YEAR-OLD Shoaib, who identifies as a transgender woman, lost her job as a flight attendant during the pandemic, she applied and got offers from leading banks, but they required her to change her gender identity. Shoaib's desire to be herself resulted in her refusing all the offers. She then applied for the role of a Customer Service Associate at Accenture in India, which has an inclusive LGBTQ+ policy. "We don't want any special treatment or behaviour. We yearn to be treated equally. That's what helps people change the notion that we are different," she says. "That culture of equality at Accenture makes all the difference," says Shoaib, who joined Accenture in India's team of more than 300,000 people in October 2020.

"We have a deep-rooted commitment to foster diversity and create an equal workplace culture. For us, Pride is about being open and committed to supporting each other in a psychologically safe environment. Our sen-

sitisation sessions are focussed on helping our people understand the nuances of gender expression and identity. In FY22, we ran a successful internal campaign to normalise the use of inclusive pronouns for our LGBTQ+ people," says Lakshmi C., MD and Lead of Human Resources at Accenture in India.

Accenture has a six-month-long inclusive internship programme that aims to build a skilled talent pool of transgender candidates. It is designed to help interns develop workplace skills, augment their work experience and establish professional networks for the future. "The programme allows us to assess prospective candidates and create a more diverse workforce," says Lakshmi. It also hires LGBTQ+ talent through strategic external partnerships, Pride employment fairs and employee referrals.

Inclusivity and diversity are important for Accenture globally. It plans to achieve a gender-balanced workforce by 2025. Globally as well as in India, nearly 47 per cent of its employees are women with 26 per cent of Accenture in India's leadership team being women, as compared to 29 per cent globally. "We continue to invest in helping our women build enduring and meaningful careers. In addition to our enabling structures such as flexible work options, gender-neutral paternal leave, benefits that enable care-

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2 ACCENTURE IN INDIA TOP ATTRIBUTES

- FAIR, OBJECTIVE PROCESSES AND POLICIES
- GROWTH AND LEARNING OPPORTUNITIES
- FLEXIBILITY AT WORK

◀ **ALL ARE WELCOME** Lakshmi C., MD and Lead-HR, Accenture in India